Asper Business Case Competition 2027

Team Briefing: Format, Rules and Deliverables

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HSBI

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What is the ABCC?

Asper Business Case Competition (ABCC)

A three-day, graduate-level business case competition hosted by the I. H. Asper School of Business, University of Manitoba, in Winnipeg, Canada. The 2027 edition (February 18–22) is the **fifth annual** competition.

- Hosted at the **Drake Centre**, 181 Freedman Crescent, University of Manitoba campus
- Teams stay at the **Delta Hotels Winnipeg** (downtown, skywalk access)
- Teams from top Canadian business schools – and, since 2026, international teams
- 2026 field: 9 graduate teams, incl. HEC Montréal, DeGroote, Beedie, Babeș-Bolyai (Romania)

Why It Matters for Us

- First-hand experience with the **North American case method** under time pressure
- Benchmarking against strong Canadian MBA/graduate teams – the 2025 field included Ivey, John Molson, HEC Montréal, Telfer, DeGroote, Beedie, Levene, Memorial and Asper
- In 2026, the international newcomer Babeș-Bolyai University **won** the competition – international teams can absolutely compete for the title
- Rich social program: team-bonding events, networking with judges from industry, gala dinner with awards

Scale of the event (2026)

35 participants, 9 faculty advisors, 50 industry judges, 52 volunteers.

Team Composition and Eligibility

- Teams consist of **four students**; all four present in every round
- Open to graduate-level students (full-time, part-time, executive MBA, and Masters-level students of other management programs)
- Each team travels with a **faculty advisor / coach** (that is me)
- Maximum of four laptops per team; **no cellphones or smartwatches** during case preparation and presentations

Golden rule

Every team member must speak in every presentation and discussion round; judging uses the official 7-category team rubric.

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A Typical Competition Week (2025 Schedule Pattern)

Day	Programme	Evening
Wednesday	Arrival, registration, division draw	Free
Thursday	**Prepared case** presentations	Museum social event
Friday	**Boardroom case**: 4 h prep + presentations	Festival du Voyageur
Saturday	**Traditional case**: 3 h prep + presentations	Finals, gala & awards
Sunday	Departure	–

- Teams present in staggered slots (division draw at registration); shuttles provided
- 2027 daily agenda still **TBA**. Both documented editions ran **Wednesday–Sunday** (2025: Wed Feb 19 – Sun Feb 23; 2026: Wed Feb 18 – Sat Feb 21, departure Sunday), but the published 2027 window Feb 18–22 falls **Thursday–Monday** – the first Thursday start in the series
- So either the window is exact (registration Thu, gala Sun, departure Mon) or the real week is **Wed Feb 17 – Sun Feb 21**. We plan to the published dates and fly an envelope that covers both

Three Rounds, Three Different Styles

Round	Prep time	Format	Weight
1: Prepared case	ca. 2 weeks (before travel)	25 min + 15 min Q&A	25 %
2: Boardroom case	short (4 h in 2026)	3 min + 22 min discussion	30 %
3: Traditional case	short (3 h in 2026)	20 min + 10 min Q&A	45 %

- Escalating difficulty and point value across the three rounds
- Top 3 teams advance to a **final round** in front of a new judge panel
- Ties broken by the highest traditional-case score

Round 1: The Prepared Case

Format

25-minute presentation + 15-minute Q&A. Unlimited slides and exhibits. Time warnings at 5 minutes (yellow) and 1 minute (red).

- Case is released **weeks before the competition** – worked on at home
- A real client: in 2026 this was **Jazz Winnipeg** (pitch a radical new operational idea)
- All resources may be used – **except** contacting employees of the case sponsor
- The coach **may** give input on this case (unlike rounds 2 and 3)
- Slide deck must be **submitted before the deadline** – late submissions are placed at the bottom of the pool

Round 2: The Boardroom Case

Format

Seated boardroom setting: 3-minute uninterrupted recommendation, then 22 minutes of open discussion with the judges (in 2026: four judges plus a company representative).

- Short preparation window on site (4 hours in 2025 and 2026)
- Protected 3 minutes: **one summary slide only** – appendices are blocked; red card at 1 minute
- Appendices unlocked for the 22-minute discussion (yellow/red cards at 5/1 minutes)
- Judges receive a **one-page black-and-white brief** in advance; deck + brief handed in on a provided USB stick
- Seated delivery via wireless keyboard/mouse; **no coach contact** after case release
- 2026 client: Coal & Canary – elevate the brand from premium to luxury

Round 3: The Traditional Case

Format

Classic case-competition style: 20-minute presentation + 10-minute Q&A. Time warnings at 5 minutes (yellow) and 1 minute (red).

- Short preparation window on site (3 hours in 2026)
- Highest weight of all rounds: **45 %** of the total score
- One laptop per student; no cellphones or smartwatches
- **No coach contact** after case release
- 2026 client: Access Credit Union – service innovations to engage young customers

The Final Round

- The **top 3 teams** present again before a fresh judge panel
- 20-minute presentation + 15-minute Q&A
- Slide decks **cannot be modified** for the final
- Faculty advisors may not communicate with their team until after the presentation
- Winners announced at the **gala dinner**

2026 podium

1. Babeș-Bolyai University (Romania) 2. DeGroote School of Business 3. HEC Montréal

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What We Must Hand In Before We Travel

1. **Registration** of the school/team with the organizers (contact: aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca – Judith Jayasuriya, Steven Harrison)
2. **Team roster**: four students + faculty advisor, with bios/photos as requested by the organizers
3. **Prepared-case slide deck** (Round 1): **.pptx only**, submitted by e-mail, file named "[Team Name] Prepared Case" – in 2025: released Feb 5, due Feb 19, 10:00 CT (registration day). Late = bottom of the pool
4. Any **forms and waivers** sent by the organizing committee after registration
5. Optional but smart: **prebuilt slide template** for the on-site rounds (explicitly allowed; build before travelling)

Note

The detailed 2027 agenda and exact deadlines are still marked TBA on the official site – they will be communicated after registration. We track them in the repository as they arrive.

Travel Checklist (Germany → Canada)

- Valid **passport** for every traveller (check expiry dates now)
- **eTA** (Electronic Travel Authorization) for visa-exempt air travellers to Canada – apply early, verify each student's citizenship requirements
- Flights to **Winnipeg (YWG)**: arrive **Feb 16 or 17**, return Feb 22 or 23 – that envelope covers both possible weekday footprints; nothing outside it is booked non-refundably until the agenda is out
- Hotel: Delta Hotels Winnipeg (competition hotel; skywalk access)
- **Travel health insurance** valid in Canada for all participants
- Winter clothing – Winnipeg in February regularly reaches $-20°$C or below

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Core Rules Across All Rounds

- Competition language: **English**; presentations must be **PowerPoint (.pptx)** – no Prezi etc.
- All four team members must speak in every round (not necessarily during the protected 3 minutes of the boardroom pitch)
- One laptop per student; no cellphones or smartwatches during prep and presentation
- No contact with the coach after release of the boardroom and traditional cases; on-site decks are collected on a provided USB stick at fixed pickup times
- Time warnings: yellow card at 5 minutes, red card at 1 minute; **late arrival = no extra time**
- Slide clickers are provided; volunteers monitor rule compliance

Fair Play, Anonymity and Allowed Tools

Disqualification risks

Revealing your **school of origin** to a judge at any point, or any coach communication during a presentation or Q&A, leads to **disqualification**. Teams compete under neutral letters (division draw at registration).

- **Internet use is allowed** during prep – including university databases and **Generative AI**
- Prebuilt **own** slide templates are permitted (built outside prep time); no third-party templates for the prepared case
- Never contact employees of a case sponsor; cases are confidential – no sharing or reproducing
- Dress code: **business professional** throughout competition days

Scoring and Tie-Breaking

Round	Weight
Prepared case	25 %
Boardroom case	30 %
Traditional case	45 %

- Rubric-based evaluation by panels of industry judges
- Ties resolved by highest traditional-case score, then by performance in the weighted rounds and individual rubric categories
- Strategic implication: **the short-prep rounds decide the competition** (75 % combined) – our training focuses accordingly

The Judging Rubric (Official, 2025 Event Guide)

Category	Weight
Implementation & resources	2.5×
Analysis	2.0×
Recommendation	2.0×
Communicating effectively	1.0×
Framing the problem	1.0×
Impact	1.0×
Measurement, risks & mitigation	1.0×

Training implication

Implementation & resources carries the highest weight (2.5×): every recommendation needs a concrete path – steps, owners, timeline, resources, and financials – not just a good idea.

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Playing to Our Strengths

Background	Natural lead role	Typical ownership
Finance	CFO of the team	Financials, valuation, sensitivity
Innovation	Creative lead	Idea generation, differentiation
Computer Science	Analytics/tech lead	Data, feasibility, digital angle
General Business	Strategist & integrator	Framing, structure, storyline

- Roles are **leads**, not silos – everyone masters the full storyline
- Rotating "presenter 1" role in practice so all four are strong openers

Preparation Roadmap (Details in the Prep Plan)

1. **Foundations** – case method, core frameworks, business math drills
2. **Skill building** – role-specific deep dives, slide craft, storylining
3. **Simulation** – weekly timed mock cases: 3 h traditional, 4 h boardroom
4. **Prepared case sprint** – structured 2-week sprint once Case 1 is released
5. **Final polish & travel** – Q&A gauntlet, dress rehearsals, logistics

Guiding principle

Train hardest for what weighs most: short-prep cases under competition-identical time limits and device rules.

Sources and Further Information

- Official page: `https://umanitoba.ca/asper/asper-business-case-competition`
- ABCC 2025 Event Guide (rules, rubric, schedule): `https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-01/abcc25-eventguide.pdf`
- Past case PDFs 2024–2026 (all nine cases): linked in `01-competition/past_cases.md` of our repository
- 2026 recap: `https://umtoday.ca/stories/forging-worldwide-relationships-2026-asper-business-case-competition`
- Instagram: @Asper_BCC Contact: aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca

Status of information

Rules and rubric follow the official 2025 Event Guide and the 2027 website; prep times and clients from 2025/2026. The 2027 agenda is TBA – re-verify all deadlines after registration.